

3.4.1.3 Fractions

If you simply enter a fraction such as 6/7, it will be interpreted as a date, as either the 6th of July or as the 7th of June, depending on your Windows settings. To make Excel accept 6/7 as a fraction, format the cell beforehand as a fraction. Alternatively, you can append a '0' before the fraction, for example, '0 6/7'.

3.4.1.4 Dates And Times

Excel interprets dates and times as numbers. Use slashes or hyphens to tell Excel that something is a date. When you enter '24/3', Excel will interpret it as the 24th of March, not as the fraction, as mentioned above. You can also specify the year, and if you don't, Excel will assume it's the current year. (Note that we're assuming you've either formatted the cells to reflect British date usage, or made a systemwide change in Windows for the same thing.)

For the 24th of March 2005, you can use any of the following:

24-03-05

24/3/05

24-3/05

24/3-05

For times, Excel uses colons. For 12 PM, you can enter '12:00:00 P.M.', or you can simply enter '12:00', or even '12:'.

Excel assumes that the time you set is AM, unless you specify the PM, or unless you use the 24-hour clock. To specify PM, use the letter 'P' or the abbreviation 'P.M.'

Another thing to remember is that '12.1' is the same as '12.01', not '12.10'.

Excel (by default) uses the 1900 date system. This simply means that the date 1 January 1900 has a true numeric value of 1, 2 Jan 1900 has a value of 2 etc. These values are called 'serial values' in Excel, and it is these serial values that allows us to use dates in calculations. Times are very similar, but Excel sees times as decimal